Like Shahrukh, Modi once again revealed himself as a master of the TV moment, never short of a memorable sound bite or a bit of political theatre. Having filed his nomination, he provided yet another quotable quote. *'Mera mann kehta hai mein aya nahi hoon, mujhe bheja bhi nahi hai. Mujhe Ma Ganga ne bulaya hai!'* (My mind tells me I have not come, nor been sent, Ma Ganga has called me here.)

But the final punchline of the day was reserved for the less voluble Shah. 'The Modi wave has now become a tsunami,' he told the throng of journalists. The Congress hit back, pointing out that the tsunami which hit the Tamil Nadu coast in December 2004 had only brought death, destruction and grief. But this could no longer be a debate over semantics. The fact is, the political earth of India had begun to shake and there was a tectonic shift taking place on the ground. The Modi nomination had been another masterful act of political choreography, but this was no longer just a manufactured 'wave'. The spontaneous upsurge of support was unmissable. The camera was not lying.

What explains this craze for Modi? He was, after all, at the start of 2013 just another chief minister, that too from a state with a relatively small pool of MPs. Within eighteen months, he was the most sought-after national figure. No state leader has ever been able to make the transition so quickly and effectively. Yes, there was a leadership vacuum in Delhi, and the invisibility of the prime minister and Rahul's immaturity had led to a desperate longing for change. The economy was in a downward spiral and big-ticket corruption had alienated the middle class. The UPA's demise was certain.

But why was Modi preferred to any other prime ministerial aspirant? My belief is Modi's USP was his staunch promise to shatter the status quo—his undiluted aggression appealed to a new India. In the 1970s, Amitabh Bachchan's angry young man persona was suited to a film-going public tiring of chocolate-box heroes. In 2014, Modi's image as a robust 'man of action' gave him a decisive edge with voters who were sick and tired of being told by a slow-moving government that 'money doesn't grow on trees'. As the man who had travelled six hours by bus to see Modi in